

DEBRIEF FORM

The Influence of Payoff Information on the Choice of Learning Strategies

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ETHICAL APPROVAL HAS BEEN GRANTED FOR THIS STUDY TO BE CARRIED OUT BETWEEN
01/10/2025 AND 30/04/2026

We would like to take this opportunity to say thank you for taking the time to participate in our study.

You were invited to take part in this study as you are a UK resident and registered Prolific user aged over 18. Please be assured, all data collected is anonymised and will be treated with the strictest confidence. No personal identifying data is collected in this study, so you will be unable to withdraw your data from the study at any time until you finish the study and submit your data, at which point your data will be anonymous. The data collected may be stored securely for a minimum of 10 years in compliance with the Data Protection Act 2018 and the EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).

The completed research will help gain an understanding of how individuals choose different learning strategies in a problem-solving task based on the social information presented. This study is being undertaken as part of a BSc Psychology degree.

You were randomly assigned to a condition that manipulated two aspects associated with the social information: whether you could or could not see the points earned (payoffs) by other players on previous trials, and the copying type. We manipulated the payoff information in three ways: random, fixed (always showing high payoff solutions), or cumulative (where solutions started off random but improved over time).

During the experiment, we allowed you to choose from three possible learning strategies: copy, innovate and maintain. When copying, we wanted you to experience the scenario as though you were engaging in an online game with three other players. This was not the case, and the three players were simulated agents designed to offer you solutions.

If you were unduly or unexpectedly affected by taking part in the study, please feel free to feed it back to the researcher, who will contact their supervisor and follow the guidance to ensure your wellbeing is supported. If you feel unable for whatever reason to talk with the researcher, then please either contact their supervisor, Dr James Winters (James.Winters@brunel.ac.uk) or the Director of Research for the Department of Psychology, Dr Byron Creese (Byron.Creese@brunel.ac.uk).

Thank you once again for your valuable contribution to this research. Your participation is greatly appreciated and will help advance our understanding in this area of psychology.